

The Grid as System: Designing Portfolio Pages with Structure

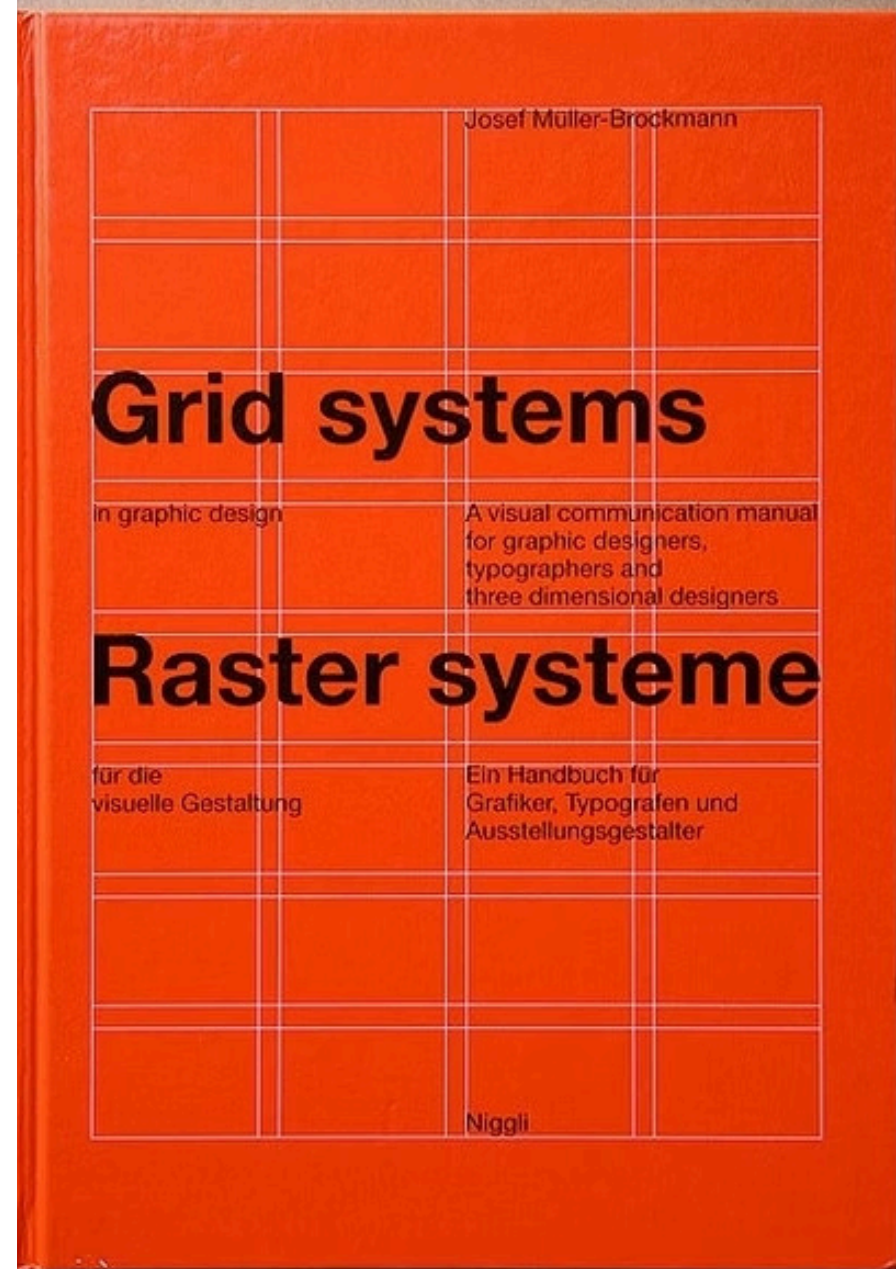
CLASS 4

ARCH - ST: PORTFOLIO_CLASS 4

In Class 4, we shift from *what* your portfolio communicates to *how* that meaning is structurally delivered on the page. If Class 3 framed narrative as a design problem, Class 4 introduces the grid as the **invisible skeletal structure** that makes narrative legible, repeatable, and professional.

Narrative does not live only in project selection or image choice—it emerges through **alignment, rhythm, hierarchy, and consistency** across pages. The grid is the underlying logic that transforms a collection of images into a coherent, designed system.

Presented by Seth Looper · Kent State University, CAED · Feb 11, 2026



Why Today Matters

A portfolio grid is not a graphic style or decorative choice. It is the **invisible skeletal structure** that organizes content, establishes hierarchy, and allows meaning to emerge clearly across pages. Today's class introduces the grid as a structural and cognitive system—one that architects already understand through column grids, modules, and baseline logic.

By learning how baseline and modular grids work together, you begin to see how portfolios move from loose collections of images to coherent, professional systems. This class lays the foundation for precision, consistency, and readability in your portfolio. Before refining layouts or aesthetics, you must first establish a grid that can support narrative, alignment, and visual rhythm across the entire document

1

Understand the grid as a structural system, not decoration

2

Recognize how grids organize hierarchy and meaning

3

Identify the role of baseline and modular grids in professional portfolios

4

Begin designing pages as part of a repeatable system rather than isolated layouts

What Is a Grid?

To understand the grid, we must recognize it as the **invisible skeletal structure** of a page. In graphic design, a grid is a framework of intersecting vertical and horizontal lines used for organizing content.

Structure vs. Decoration: A grid does not decorate a page; it structures meaning.

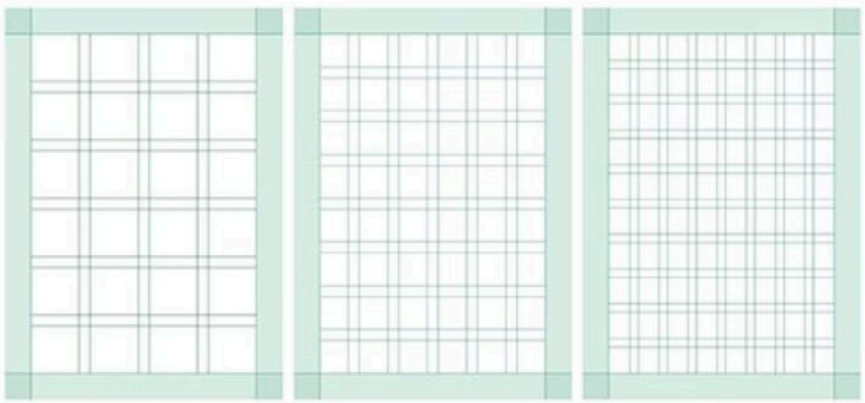
Systemic Logic: It transforms a simple collection of images into a coherent, professional system.

Table Of Contents Strategic Foundation Tone Of Voice Visual Identity Logo Monogram Typography Colors Photography Brand Elements Grid Systems and Layouts Applications Documentation Appendices	Grid Systems and Layouts	7.1 Margins & Columns 7.2 Types of Grid Systems 7.3 Layout Digital 7.4 Layout Print
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7.2

Types of Grid Systems

This section details three grid system examples meticulously engineered so that rows and columns are always divisible by 2, providing a robust and adaptable framework. These grids are foundational in creating designs that are visually coherent and structurally sound, supporting everything from complex web pages to streamlined print media. Each example is designed to optimize the spatial distribution of text, images, and other graphic elements across diverse applications.



After creating the margins create 4 columns and 6 rows to create our content grid.

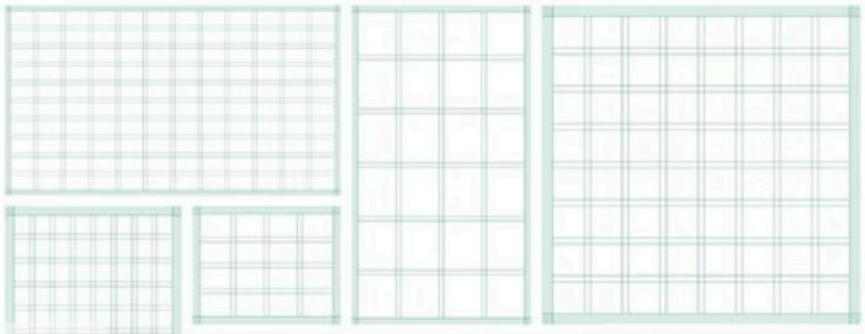
For additional flexibility continue to divide the layout into a 48 field or a 96 field modular grid.

Divide the layouts depending on the content and what suits best the composition.

7.2

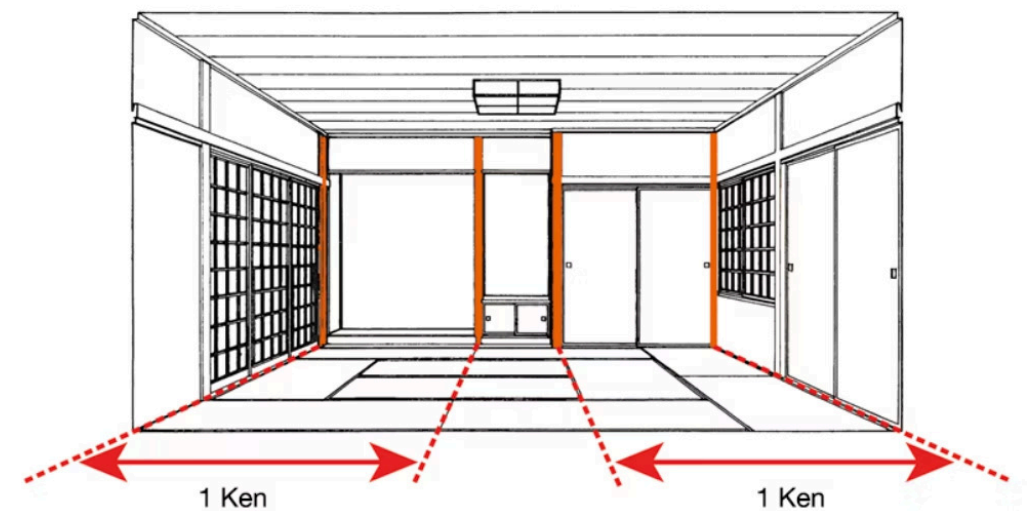
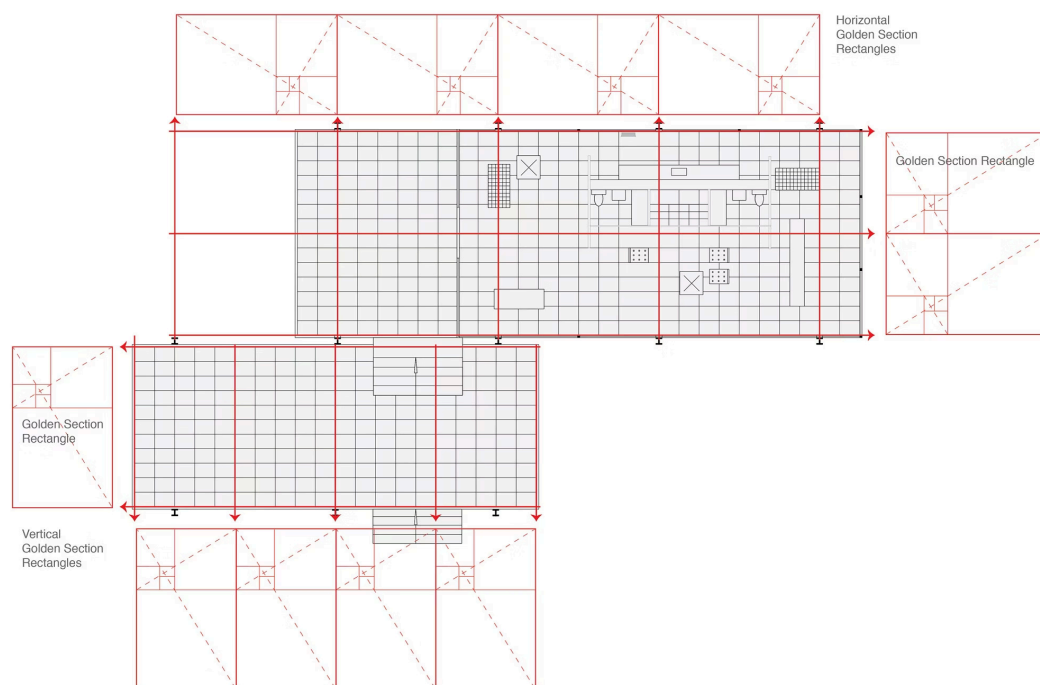
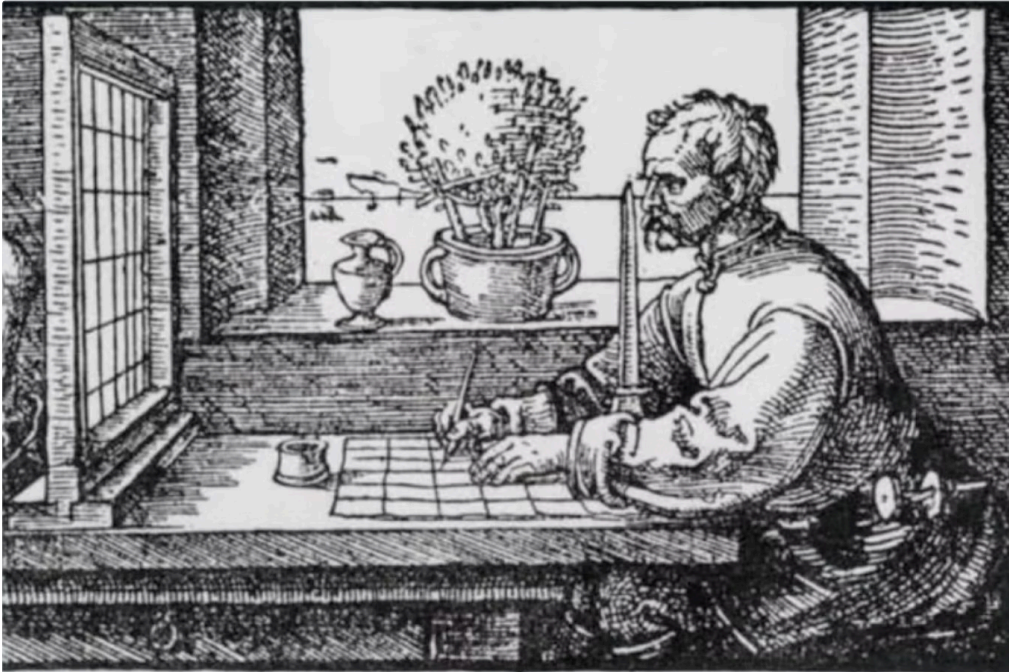
Flexibility

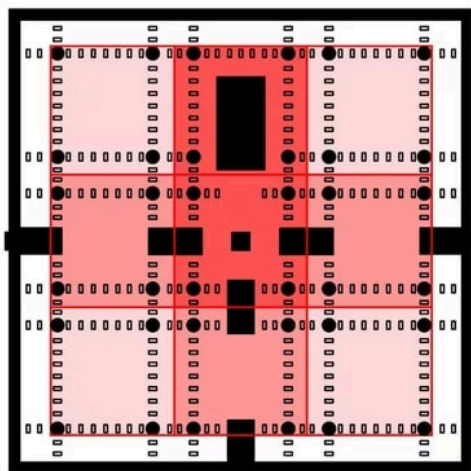
Highlighting the adaptability of our grid systems, this page features numerous configurations demonstrating how our design approach accommodates a wide range of creative demands. From annual reports to digital banners, the versatility of our grids ensures that designers have the freedom to innovate while maintaining a cohesive and engaging visual narrative. Each grid example shows potential applications and modifications, illustrating our commitment to dynamic yet consistent design solutions.



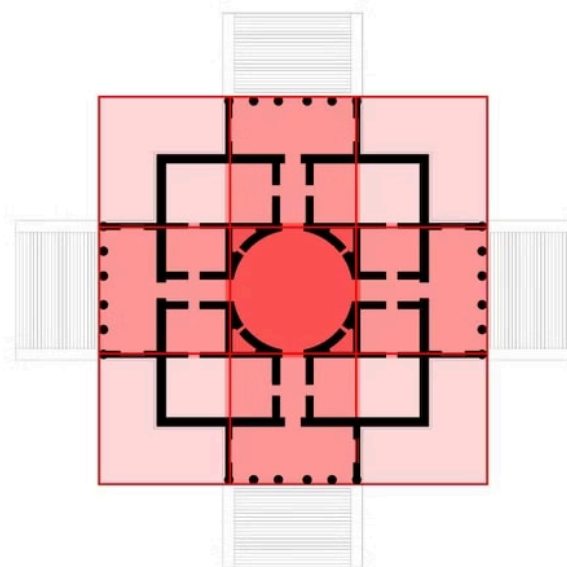
A Brief History of the Grid

For architects, the grid is a familiar language and one of the oldest organizing principles in human civilization.

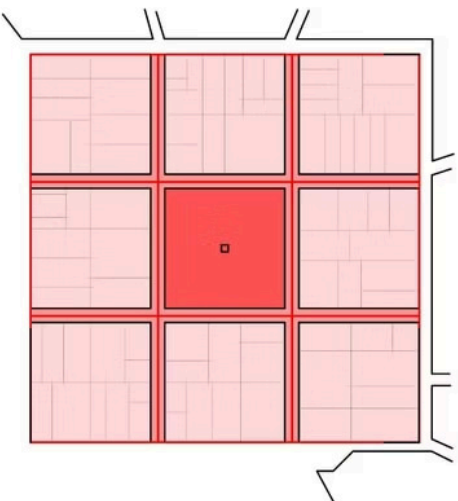




TEMPLE OF SOLOMON
JUAN BAUTISTA VILLALPANDO | 1596



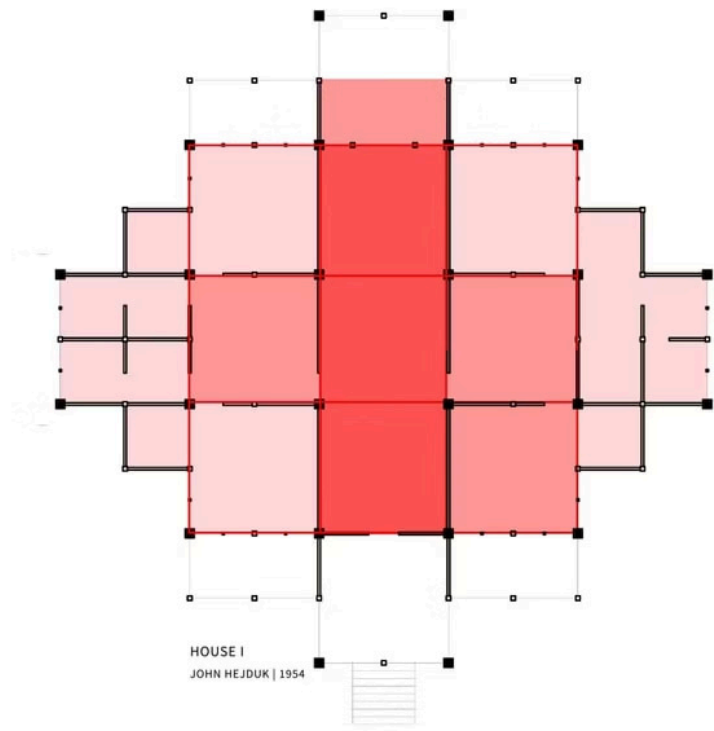
LA VILLA CAPRA
ANDREA PALLADIO | 1565



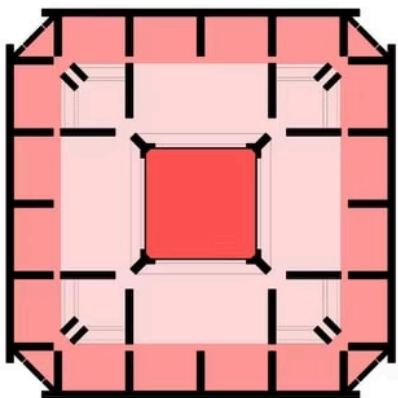
NEW HAVEN MASTER PLAN
JOHN DAVENPORT | 1641



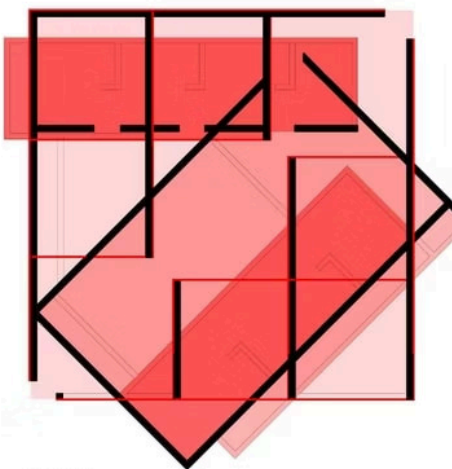
VILLA SAVOYE
LE CORBUSIER | 1931



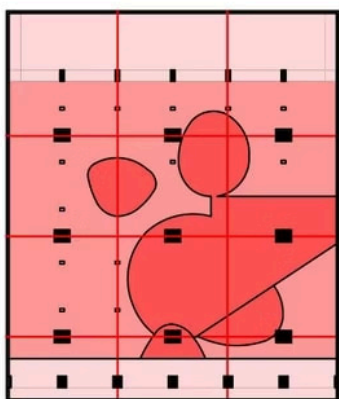
HOUSE I
JOHN HEJDUK | 1954



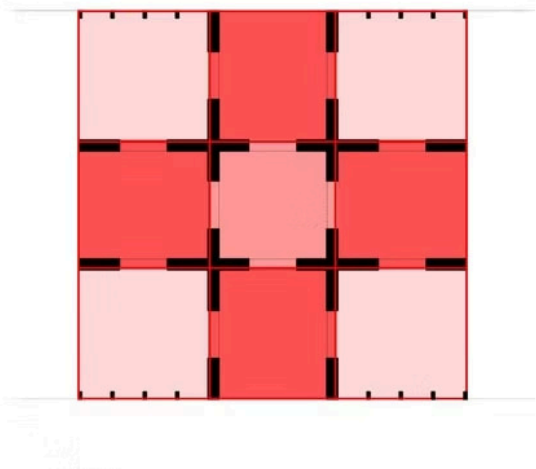
PHILLIPS EXETER ACADEMY LIBRARY
LOUIS KAHN | 1971



HOUSE III
PETER EISENMAN | 1971



TRÉS GRANDE BIBLIOTHÈQUE
OMA | 1989

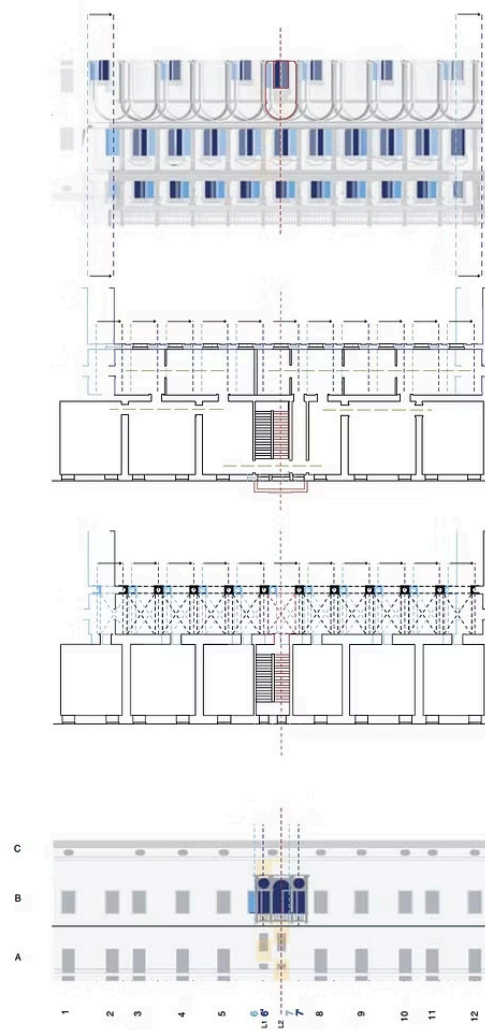


VILLA
KERSTEN GEERS | 2010

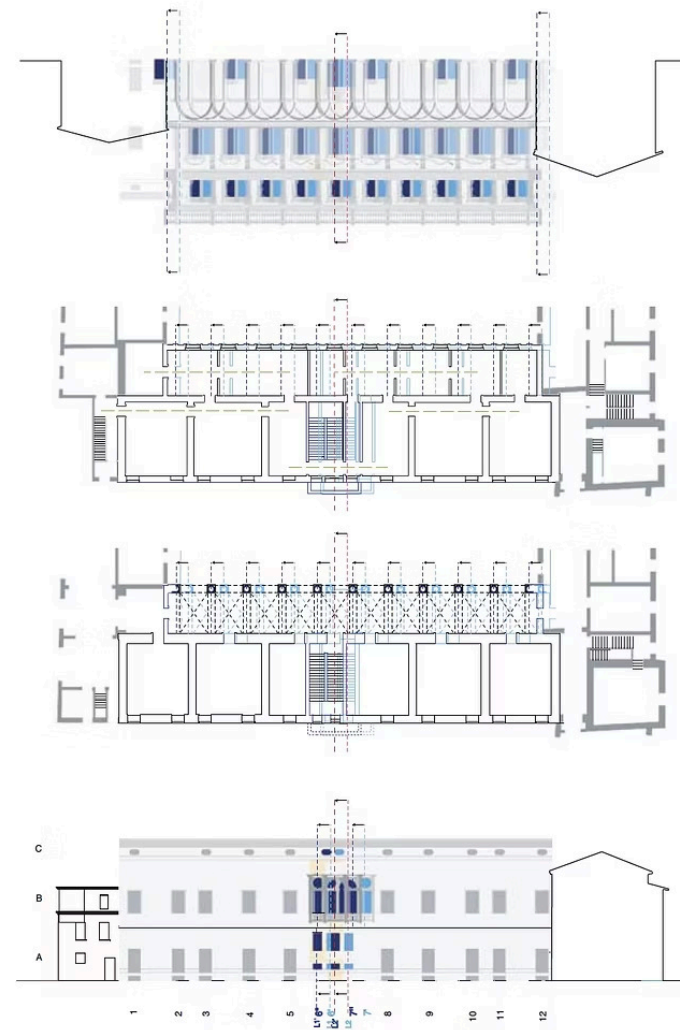
26

Diagram 3

In order for the whole stair to maintain a central position, the entrance to the stairwell and one bay of the loggia are displaced such that they are centered on the first run of the switchback. This centralization requires the relocation of both the entire symmetrical group of doors and all ten bays of the loggia. Asserting the new center is a *serliana*, which appears on the rear façade at the culmination of the stair.



3



4

Diagram 4

The stair, loggia, and *serliana*, now bound by a shared axis, are altogether displaced by peripheral pre-existing elements. Due to the idiosyncratic existing fragment of the *castello* and the particular dimensions of rooms and loggia bays of the palazzo, the necessary relocation of the stair and accompanying *serliana* disturbs the otherwise nearly symmetrical patterns of rooms and windows at the back as built. (Note that the room at the far left end—when facing the rear façade—is anomalous and apparently predates the stair in the built version.)

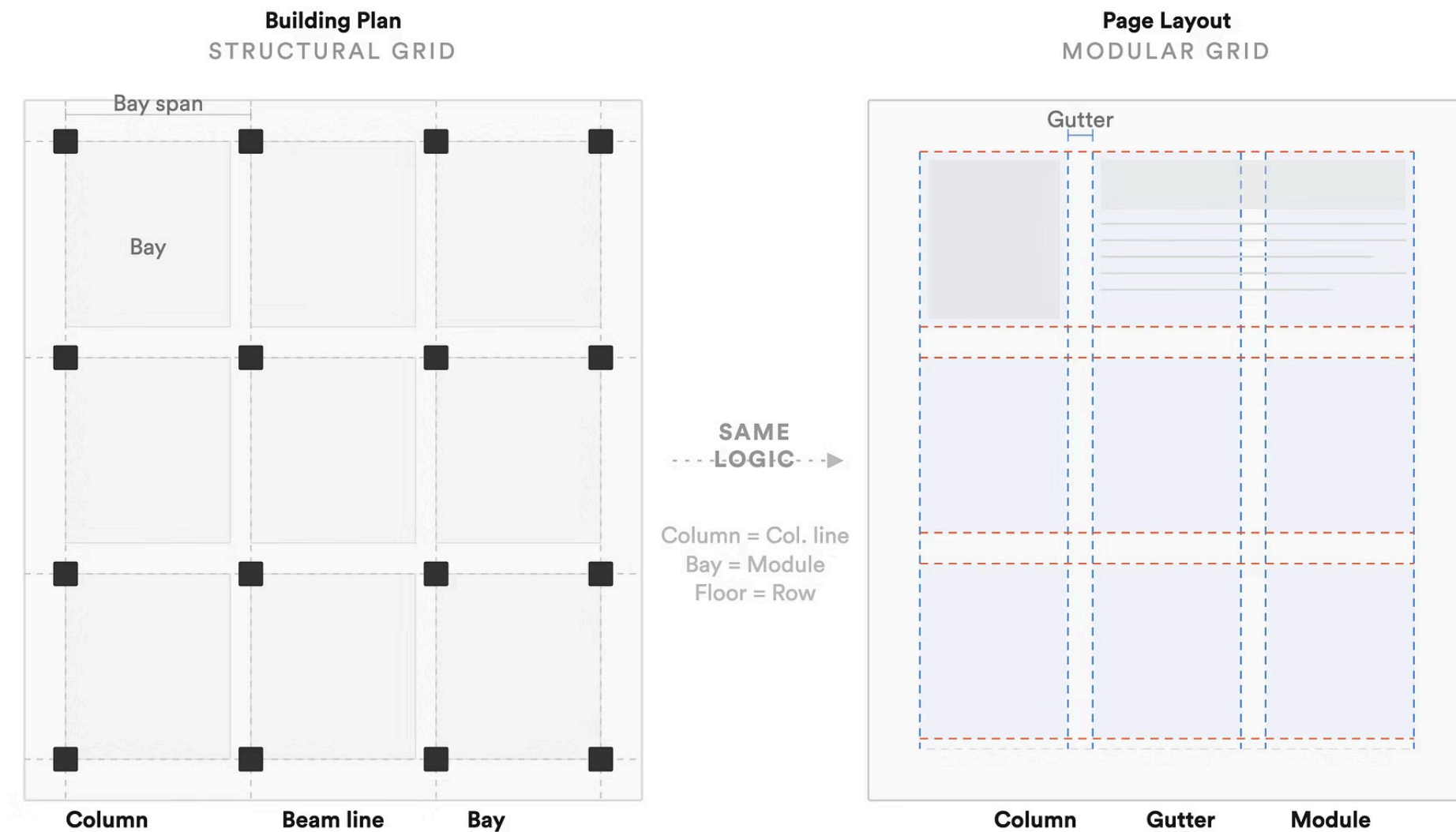
27

The Foundation of Precision

A grid is a structural framework where every element exists in a purposeful relationship to the others.

- **Consistency:** Establishes a recurring visual rhythm that guides the reader across spreads.
- **Organization:** Manages varied content—plans, sections, and diagrams—without the layout feeling accidental.
- **Cognitive Ease:** Allows viewers to process information quickly through a legible hierarchy.

Structural Column Grid vs. Page Grid



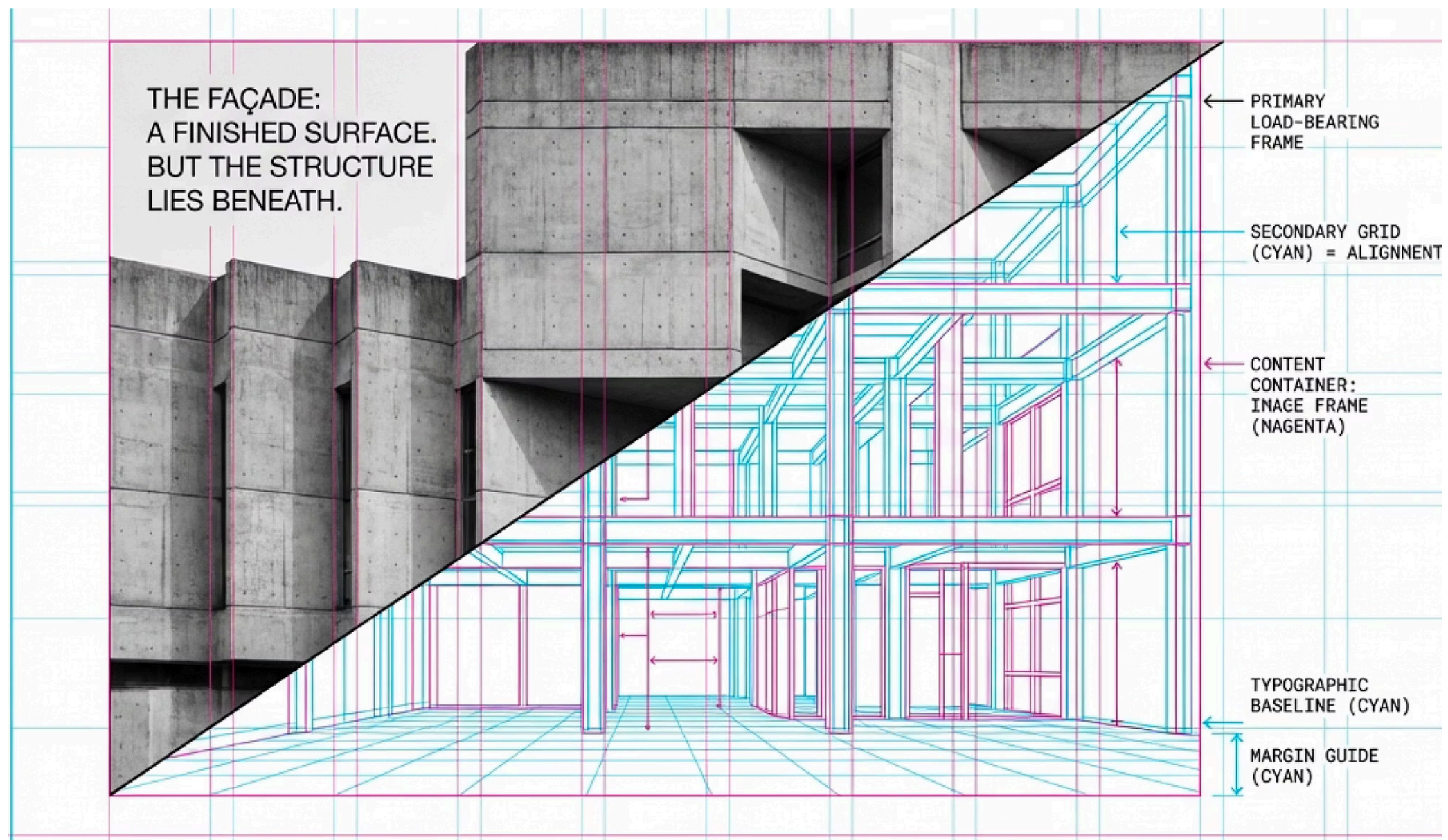
The logic is identical: both grids define rhythm, structure, and zones for content.

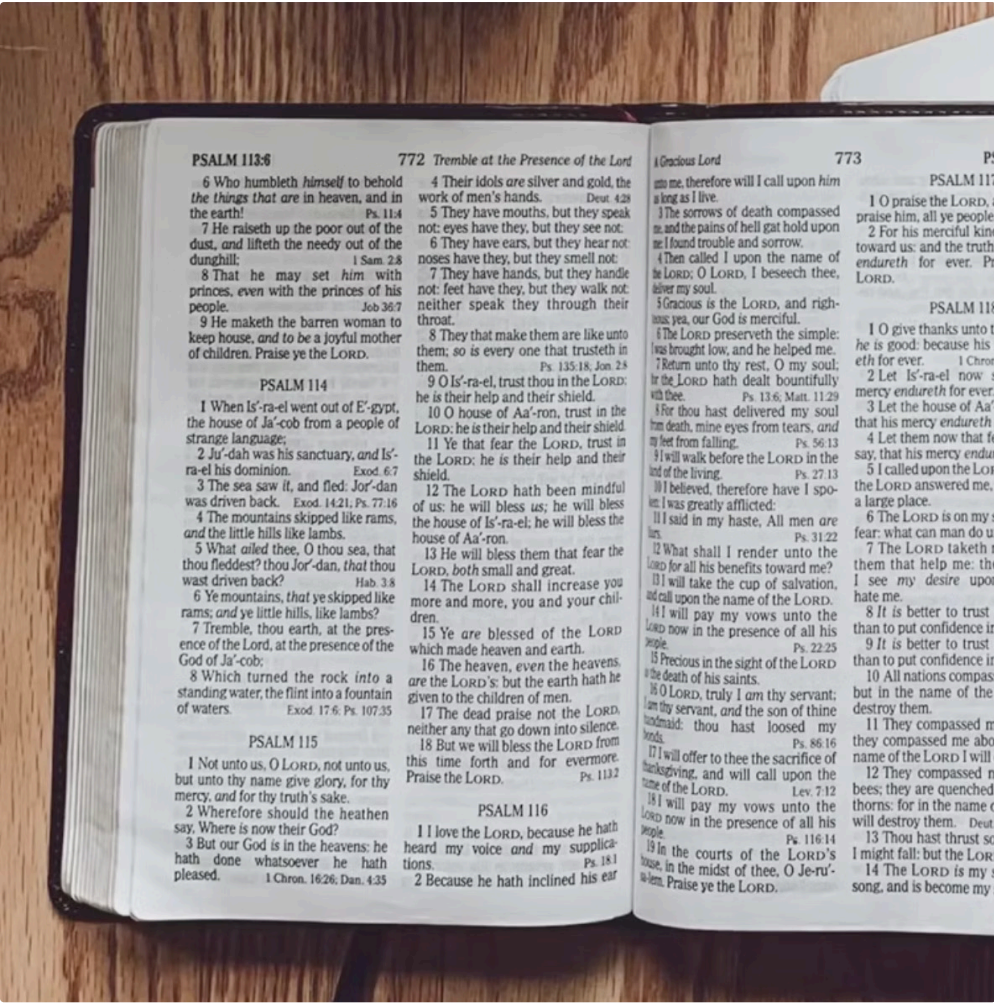
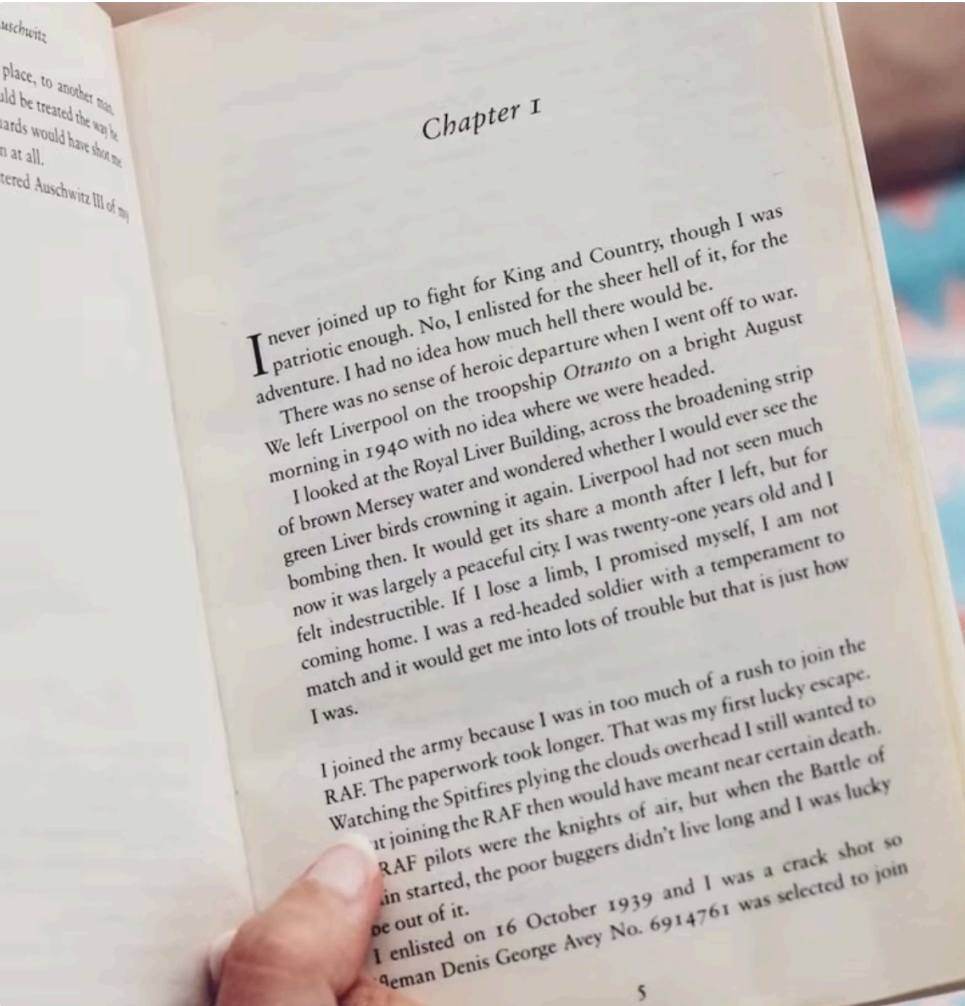
A building without a grid is a pile of materials; a portfolio without a grid is a collection of images.

The Design Analogy: Drawing on the Site

In architecture, design begins with a **column grid**—the underlying logic that allows a building to stand.

- **The Foundation:** The **Baseline Grid** ensures every line of text sits on stable ground.
- **Structural Bays:** The **Modular Grid** defines zones for drawings, renders, diagrams, and text.
- **Spatial Rhythm:** The grid defines how loads are carried and determines where flexibility is possible.





Types of Grids

Different content types require specific structural approaches.

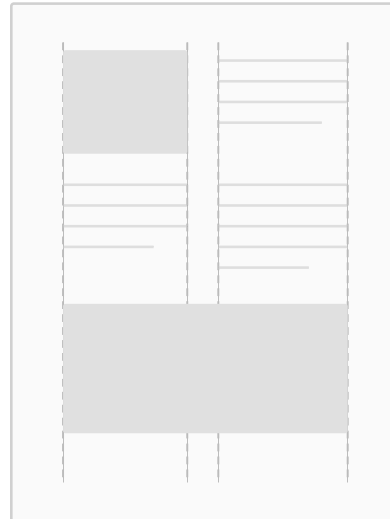
Common Types of Grids

Manuscript
Single text column



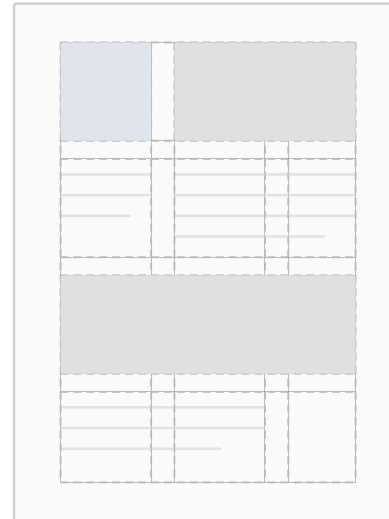
Books, theses,
long-form writing

Column
Vertical divisions



Magazines,
editorial layouts

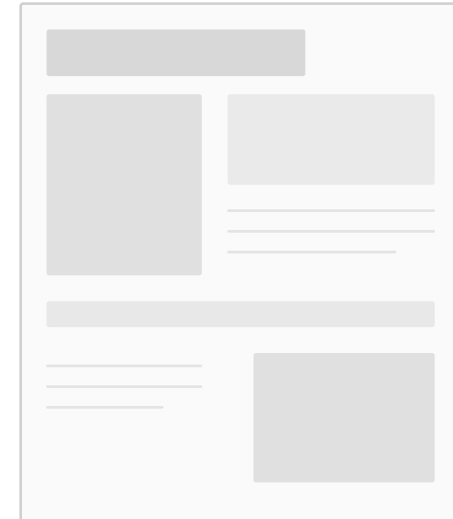
Modular
Columns + rows



Architectural portfolios,
catalogs

RECOMMENDED

Hierarchical
Content-driven



Websites,
experimental posters

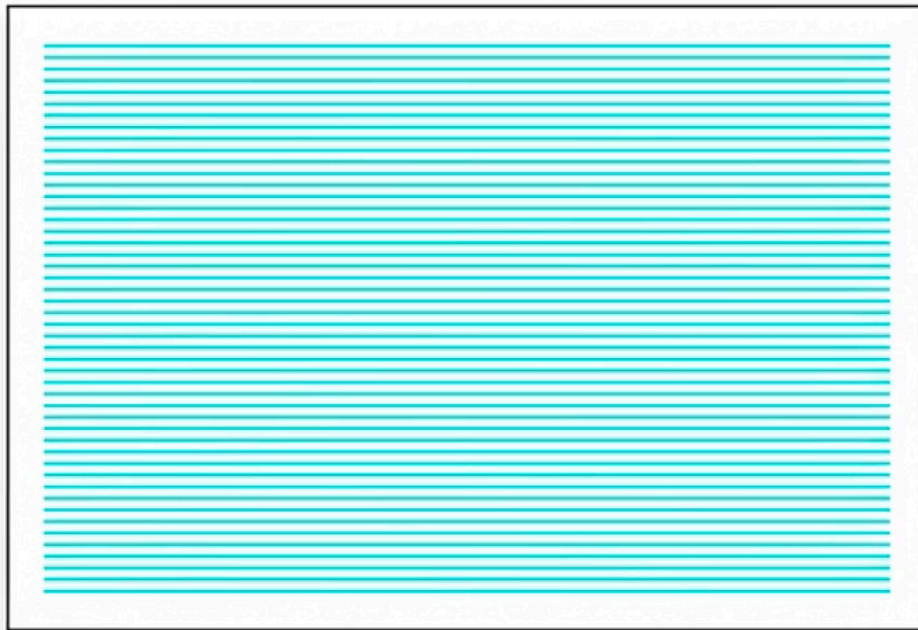
For architectural portfolios, the modular grid (third from left) is the recommended system.

The Ideal System: Baseline + Modular

For architectural portfolios, the **Modular Grid** paired with a **Baseline Grid** is the professional standard.

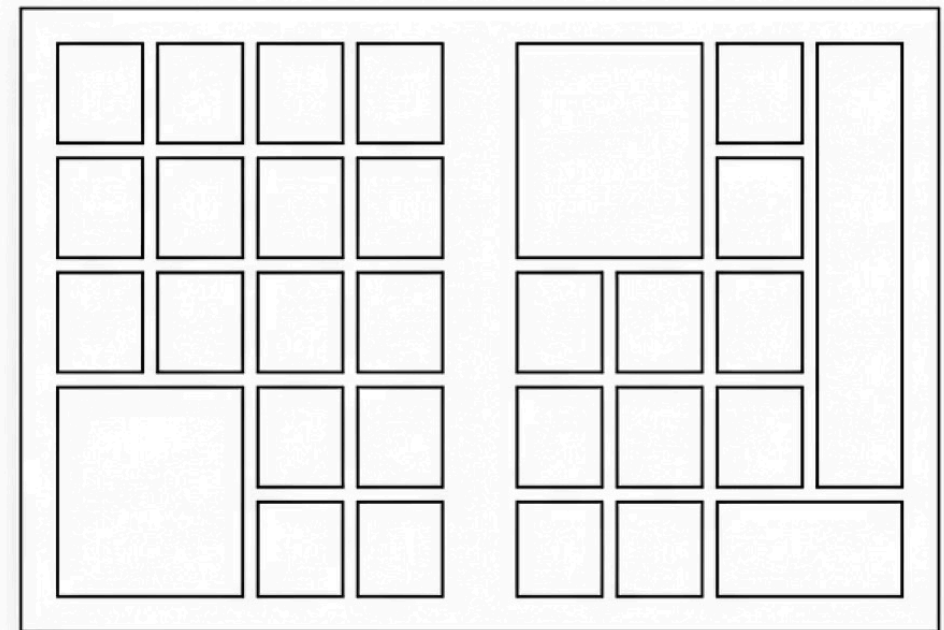
- **Absolute Alignment:** Without a baseline grid, text across adjacent columns subtly drifts.
- **Structural Integrity:** The 12-pt baseline functions like rebar within concrete—it makes the page feel stable and complete.

Two Systems, One Goal



The Baseline Grid

Precision. Ensures text aligns perfectly across columns and pages.



The Modular Grid

Organization. A flexible system to arrange images, sidebars, and varied content.

Alone, they have limitations. Combined, they offer rigorous alignment within a flexible structure.

From Intuition to Structural Logic

We often describe portfolio layouts as "working" or "not working" based on intuition, but professional clarity is the result of a deliberate structural system. Today, we move from the **Narrative Outline** you created in Class 3 to a **Structural Framework** that makes that narrative legible.

The "Atomic Unit" Approach

- **Precision over Guesswork:** We will establish the **12-point leading** as the atomic unit that governs every spatial decision on your page.
- **Systemic Alignment:** Your margins, gutters, and image modules must all resolve as multiples of this 12-point unit to ensure mathematical harmony.
- **Structural Bays:** Think of your modular grid as a series of structural bays where your plans, sections, and text are "constructed" rather than just placed.

Goals for Today's Activity

- **Set Up the Foundation:** Configure your InDesign workspace with a Baseline and Modular grid system.
- **Stress-Test the Narrative:** Place your narrative sequence from Class 3 into this new system to see where the structure forces better hierarchy.
- **Identify "Grid Drift":** Learn to recognize when elements float inconsistently and how to snap them to the baseline for professional resolution.

Technical Guide: The Workspace Setup

Before we begin, ensure your InDesign panels are organized for precision:

- **Pages & Layers:** Kept visible to manage Master Pages and separate drawings from annotations.
- **Align & Pathfinder:** Crucial for precisely positioning elements relative to the grid lines.
- **Paragraph Styles:** Your primary tool for maintaining the 12-point rhythm across all text blocks.

The Logic of 12: Why It Is the "Golden Number"

In this system, the **leading** (vertical space between lines of text) is not just a typographic choice; it is the **atomic unit** of the entire page . Every other dimension—margins, gutters, and image heights—is a multiple of this single unit.

1. Why 12 Points? (Mathematical Harmony)

- Divisibility:** Twelve is one of the most highly divisible numbers (1, 2, 3, 4, 6). This allows for varied layouts that still align perfectly.
- No Fractions:** Designing around 12 ensures your margins and guides resolve as whole-number values rather than decimals, preventing "pixel drift".

2. The Relationship to Scale (The A3/Tabloid Standard)

- Font Size:** For an 11" x 17" (Tabloid/A3-approximate) spread, a font size between **9.5 pt** and **10 pt** provides professional density and readability .
- The "Golden" Ratio:** Pairing a 10 pt font with **12 pt leading** creates enough "breathing room" to be legible while remaining compact enough for professional architectural standards .

3. The "Atomic" Effect

- The 12-pt Unit:** Think of this like a brick size in masonry. If the brick is 12 units high, then every wall (column), window (image module), and door (gutter) must be a multiple of 12 to fit into the system .
- Structural Integrity:** When text and images resolve to the same underlying 12-pt rhythm, the page feels stable, intentional, and complete—much like rebar within concrete.

Visual Summary

Element	Dimension	Logic
Leading	12 pt	The Primary Atomic Unit
Margins	36 pt / 48 pt	Multiples of 12 (12 x 3 and 12 x 4)
Gutters	12 pt	Matches the atomic unit for perfect alignment
Rows	8	Divides the page into "structural bays"
Columns	6	

Phase 1: Preparing the Digital Site

Maintaining organized panels is essential for precision and efficiency. Before we construct the grid, we must configure InDesign to function as a professional design environment.

Step 1: The Workspace Reset

- Go to the **Workspace Switcher** in the top-right corner.
- Select **Essentials** and then select **Reset Essentials**.
- This clears old clutter and gives you a blank slate to build your system.

Step 2: Activating Your Core Panels

Open the specific tools required for architectural precision via the **Window** menu :

- **Pages & Layers:** Go to Window > Pages and Window > Layers. These are your primary navigation and structural hierarchy tools .
- **Links:** Go to Window > Links to track your placed project images and external drawings.
- **Object Control:** Go to Window > Object & Layout > Align. The **Pathfinder** usually opens with it—use these for precisely positioning elements relative to grid lines.
- **Typography:** Go to Window > Styles > Paragraph Styles. This is your most important tool for maintaining the **12-point rhythm**.
- **Properties:** Go to Window > Properties for a centralized dashboard of your selected object attributes.
- **Control Bar:** Go to Window > Control. Ensure your \$X, Y, W,\$ and \$H\$ values are always multiples of **12 pt** to maintain mathematical harmony .

Step 3: Organizing the Dock

To make your workspace "**scannable**" like a modular grid:

- **Group Panels:** Click and drag the tab of a panel (e.g., **Layers**) and hover over another (e.g., **Pages**) until a blue highlight appears. Release to "tab" them together.
- **Docking:** Drag the entire group to the right edge of the screen until a vertical blue bar appears.
- **Collapse to Icons:** If you want more screen space for your layout, click the small **double-arrow (>>)** at the top of the panel dock to collapse them into icons.

Step 4: Saving the "Class 4" Workspace

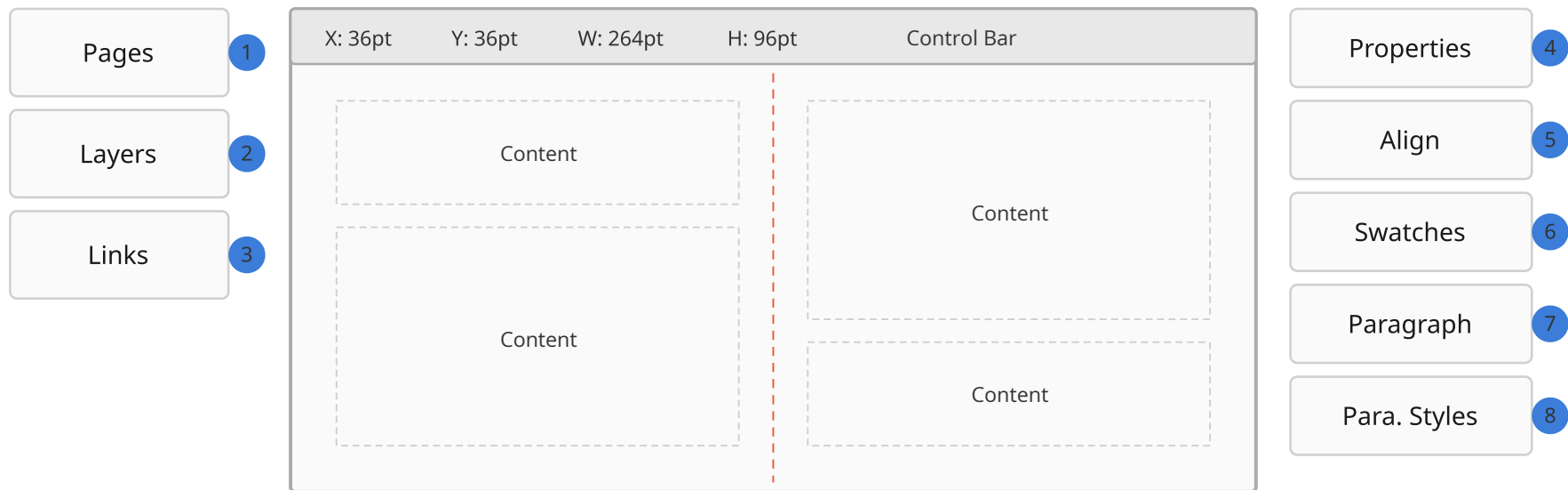
1. Go to the **Workspace Switcher > New Workspace**.
2. Name it "**New Portfolio System**".

PHASE 1

Preparing the Digital Site — Workspace Setup

- 1** **Workspace Reset**
Workspace Switcher > Essentials > Reset Essentials
- 2** **Activate Core Panels**
Open Pages, Layers, Links, Align, Paragraph Styles, Properties, Control Bar
- 3** **Organize the Dock**
Group panels by dragging tabs together, dock to right edge, collapse to icons
- 4** **Save Workspace**
Workspace Switcher > New Workspace > "Class 4_Portfolio System"

Annotated InDesign Workspace



Drag panel tabs together to group — dock groups to the right edge — collapse with >> icon

1 Pages: Navigate spreads
5 Align: Distribute elements

2 Layers: Content hierarchy
6 Swatches: Color library

3 Links: Track placed assets
7 Paragraph: Text formatting

4 Properties: Object attributes
8 Para. Styles: Predefined text styles

Save as: "Class 4_Portfolio System"

Phase 2: Technical Execution of the "Atomic Unit"

In this system, **leading**—the vertical space between lines—is the atomic unit of the entire document. Every decision must resolve as a multiple of this unit.

Step 1: Document Setup

- **Units:** Ensure your document units are set to **Points**.
- **Dimensions:**
 - **Width:** 600 pt.
 - **Height:** 840 pt.
- **Pages:** Start with **14 pages** (7 spreads) and ensure **Facing Pages** is checked.

Step 2: Configuring the Baseline Grid

- **Preferences:** Navigate to InDesign > Preferences > Grids (Mac) or Edit > Preferences > Grids (PC).
- **Start Point:** Set the grid to start at **0 pt** relative to the **Top Margin**.
- **Increment:** Set the grid to increment every **12 pt**.
- **View:** To see your work, go to View > Grids & Guides > Show Baseline Grid.
 - *Note: If it doesn't appear, zoom in. Grids often hide at low zoom levels.*

Step 3: Setting Margins & Columns

- **Navigate:** Go to Layout > Margins and Columns.
- **Top Margin:** 36 pt (\$12 \times 3\$).
- **Bottom Margin:** 48 pt (\$12 \times 4\$).
- **Inside/Outside:** Set to **36 pt** for a balanced frame.
- **Columns:** Set to **6** with a **12 pt gutter**.
 - *This creates your primary vertical divisions.*

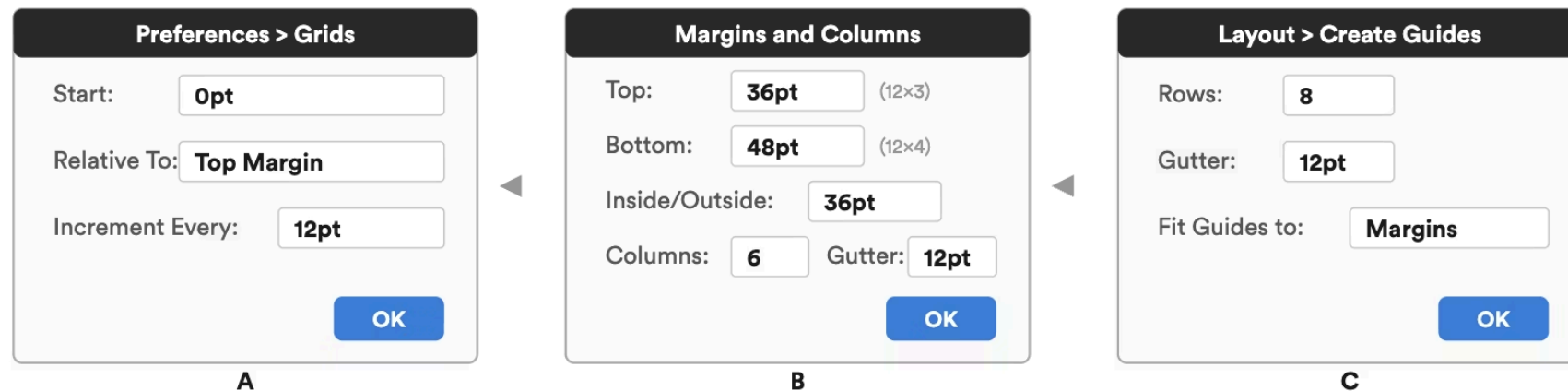
Step 4: Constructing the Modular Grid (Rows)

- **Navigate:** Go to Layout > Create Guides.
- **Rows:** Set to **8** with a **12 pt gutter**.
- **Columns:** Leave as is (or set to 6 if not done in Step 3).
- **Fitting: CRITICAL:** Ensure you select **"Fit Guides to: Margins"**.
- **Result:** Each module now contains exactly 7 lines of content plus 1 line for the gutter.

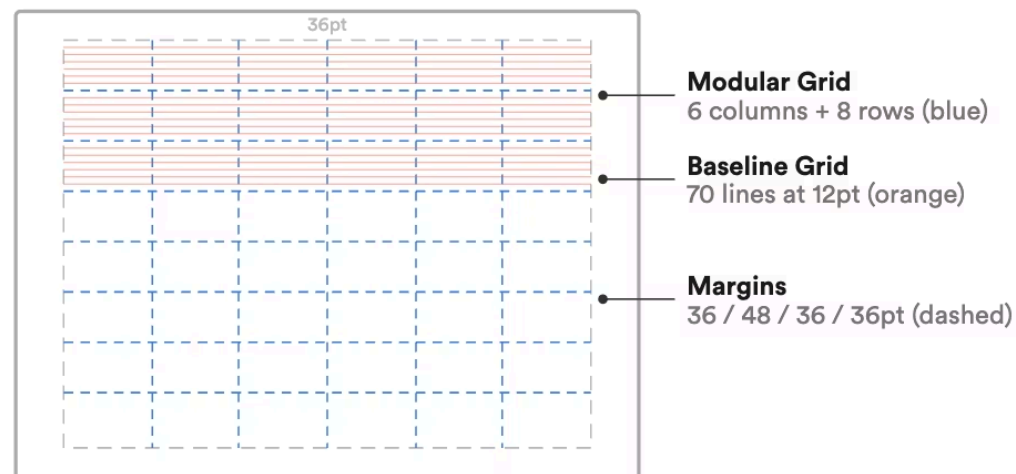
PHASE 2

Technical Execution of the "Atomic Unit"

- 1 Document Setup**
Units: Points | Width: 600pt | Height: 840pt | 14 pages (7 spreads) | Facing Pages
- 2 Baseline Grid**
Preferences > Grids | Start: 0pt (Top Margin) | Increment: 12pt | View > Show Baseline Grid
- 3 Margins & Columns**
Layout > Margins and Columns | Top: 36pt | Bottom: 48pt | Inside/Outside: 36pt | 6 columns, 12pt gutter
- 4 Modular Grid (Rows)**
Layout > Create Guides | 8 rows, 12pt gutter | Fit Guides to: Margins | Result: 7 content lines + 1 gutter



Result: 600 × 840pt Page with Both Grids Active



— Modular grid (6 cols + 8 rows) — Baseline grid (12pt increment)

Phase 3: Constructing the System

Working in groups, you will now apply the 12-point "Atomic Unit" to your Class 3 narrative sequence. Help each other troubleshoot the technical setup and alignment.

- **The Task:** Open your Class 3 narrative sequence and apply the 12-pt Baseline and 8-row Modular Grid.
- **Layout:** Place your images and text into the "structural bays" defined by your modules.
- **Goal:** Arrange your 7 spreads as best as you can within the grid constraints—focus on spatial rhythm and logic.
- **Time:** 20 Minutes.
- **Collaboration:** Use this time to troubleshoot "grid drift" and alignment issues with your peers.

Common Mistake: Baseline Drift

With Baseline Grid
ALIGNED



Baselines align across columns.
The page feels stable and resolved.

Without Baseline Grid
DRIFTING



Baselines drift between columns.
The page feels unresolved and unprofessional.

Always pair your modular grid with a baseline grid to maintain vertical register across columns.

Synthesizing Grid Insights

Before we move on, we'll pause to capture what we learned together from the grid construction activity.

01

Open the [shared group spreadsheet](#)

02

Write 2–3 key takeaways from today's exercise

F

03

Consider these guiding prompts:

- **Structural Logic:** How did the 12-point "Atomic Unit" change the way you see the page: as a canvas for decoration or a site for construction?
- **Consistency:** What surprised you about how a baseline grid resolves "grid drift" and unprofessional floating text?
- **Intentionality:** What will you do differently now that you see "White Space" as a designed module rather than leftover space?

These collective takeaways will help us establish a shared language and foundational understanding for future classes.

Grid Foundations

This assignment builds directly on today's technical exercise and prepares your portfolio infrastructure for the rest of the term.

Your Task:

1. **Refine the System:** Apply the **12-point "Atomic Unit"** logic to the project you outlined in Class 3 .
2. **Structural Alignment:** Ensure all project statements and images resolve strictly to the **Baseline** and **Modular** grids .
3. **Finalize the Sequence:** Complete the layout of your **Project Introduction** and **6 project spreads** (7 spreads total) within the grid.

Goal:

The goal is not a "perfect" or "finished" layout. Focus on getting familiar with the **structural rhythm** and ensuring no text is "drifting" between baseline units .

Submission Format:

- **Create a New Folder:** Name it "**Class 4**".
- **Upload a PDF:** The document must contain an introduction page and 6 spreads of the project.
- **Check Your Work:** Ensure your margins (36pt/48pt) and gutters (12pt) align with the mathematical system established today.

Quick Reference: Essential Shortcuts

Action	Mac	Windows
Preview Mode	W	W
Open Preferences	Cmd+K	Ctrl+K
Show/Hide Baseline Grid	Opt+Cmd+'	Alt+Ctrl+'
Show/Hide Guides	Cmd+;	Ctrl+;
Snap to Guides	Shift+Cmd+;	Shift+Ctrl+;
Place File	Cmd+D	Ctrl+D
Fit Spread in Window	Opt+Cmd+0	Alt+Ctrl+0
Create Guides	Layout Menu	Layout Menu